

Desert locusts and late unseasonable rainfall continue to threaten the ongoing Meher harvest

Key Messages

- Desert locusts continue to threaten the ongoing *Meher* harvest. According to FAO, locusts have invaded an estimated 56 woredas of Afar, Amhara, Oromia, Somali, and Tigray regions. In Amhara, nearly 75,000 hectares of both crop and rangeland were infested according to the Regional Bureau of Agriculture. Some localized areas are reporting crop losses and households are harvesting immature crops to avoid large-scale crop losses. In affected pastoral areas of Afar, Oromia, and Somali Regions, desert locusts are feeding on pasture and vegetation, which is decreasing the availability for livestock. Desert Locusts are expected to continue hatching, specifically in Somali Region as conditions are largely favorable for breeding. Current protection measures are unable to control the outbreak due to the rugged nature of the topography and conflict in some areas.
- Unseasonable rainfall continued in November 2019, which has started to negatively impact the *Meher* harvest in areas of Oromia, Amhara, and Tigray regions. Since most *Meher* crops are at the ripening and harvesting stages, the unseasonable rainfall is causing some crop seed shattering and rotting. If unseasonable rain continues, there is likely to be a decrease in the *Meher* harvest at the household level in affected areas, although, the full extent of the impact of both the unseasonable rainfall and desert locusts is yet to be fully assessed. However, national *Meher* production is still expected to be average.
- Cumulative rainfall for the October to December *Deyr/Hagaya* season is significantly above average due to heavy rainfall in October. Rainfall continued in November, although not as heavy as in October. The heavy October rainfall resulted in flooding in riverain areas resulting in the damage of household assets, infrastructure, and the displacement of households. Despite the short-term impacts, flooding in the long term typically has a positive effect, improving pastureland and water for livestock. This is expected to improve livestock production and productivity in the medium term. Since reports of flooding in mid-October, no new flooding events have been reported.
- Due to the combined impacts of conflict and below average *Belg* and *Kiremt* 2019 seasonal rains in areas of the country, Crisis (IPC Phase 3) outcomes are present along the Tekeze catchment of Tigray and Amhara and north pastoral areas of Afar, east and west Hararghe, lowlands of Bale and Guji and Borana Zones of Oromia. Additionally, most parts of Somali Region are also in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) where households continue to have below average herd sizes. The rest of the country is facing Stressed (IPC Phase 2) or Minimal (IPC Phase 1), specifically areas where the *Meher* harvest is ongoing.

* FEWS NET's classifications are IPC-compatible. IPC-compatible analysis follows key IPC protocols but does not necessarily reflect the consensus of national food security partners. As of IPC 3.0, the IPC no longer assesses the impact of food assistance on classification and thus no longer maps the (!). However, FEWS NET continues to produce food security maps inclusive of the (!) as well as maps compatible with IPC 3.0/3.1, which include the mapping of food security assistance bags. FEWS NET and the IPC use different methods to estimate the total Population in Need of humanitarian food assistance and assess the risk of Famine. Learn more at www.fews.net/about.

Key Message Update

This Key Message Update provides a high-level analysis of current acute food insecurity conditions and any changes to FEWS NET's latest projection of acute food insecurity outcomes in the specified geography. Learn more [here](#).